

The Glorious King of Tantras of Secret Wisdom

Śrī Jñānaguhyatantrarāja · Toh 392 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་ཤེས་རབ་གསང་བའི་རྩ་ཀྱི་ལྷ་པོ་

Toh 392 in the Kangyur is a tantric text known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Jñānaguhyatantrarāja and in Tibetan as the Glorious King of Tantras of Secret Wisdom, rendered into English as The Glorious King of Tantras of Secret Wisdom. It belongs to the class of Vajrayāna tantras and is concerned with the esoteric teachings of the generation stage, including the nature of deities, the sixty-four excellent marks, the thirty-seven factors of awakening, the five wisdoms, and the four empowerments as expressions of the body's channel-wheels. The text is presented in a condensed instructional style, with short declarative lines addressed to a practitioner in the manner characteristic of higher tantric literature. It was translated into Tibetan by the Indian paṇḍita Gayādhara together with the Tibetan monk-translator Śākya Yeshe, a renowned collaboration responsible for several important tantric transmissions in the canon.

The King of Tantras, the Glorious Tantra of Great Power, is complete.

This was translated by the paṇḍita Gayādhara and the translator, the monk Śākya Yeshe.

In the language of India: Śrī Jñānaguhyatantrarāja. In the language of Tibet: The Glorious King of Tantras of Secret Wisdom.

Homage to the Glorious Great Bliss.

Homage to the essence — the lord of the four channel-wheels of one's own body, which is the thirty-seven factors of awakening (bodhipakṣadharmā). Tell me the suchness of the four empowerments. Listen!

O lord of the vajra essence — the suchness of the deities of the generation stage is to be explained first. The sixty-four are the excellent marks. The thirty-seven are the factors of awakening. The five are the five wisdoms. The sole hero is the dharmadhātu. The hand-emblems, body colors, and the rest are taught elsewhere.

The measure of the secret vajra and bell is held to be a barleycorn and a finger-joint. That suchness is skillful means and wisdom. In ultimate truth they are inseparable. There is nothing to meditate upon; there is no meditator. There is nothing whatsoever attained through meditation. It is not produced by cause and condition. At the ground of mind are the five buddha bodies. There

is no teacher and no teaching. Free from all fear and all conceptual thought — that is the suchness of the fourth. The suchness of the first is wind. The life-force and effort are A and HŪṂ. A signifies that all phenomena are, from the very beginning, unborn. HŪṂ signifies that which is empty of the duality of apprehended and apprehender. Arising and engaging — the three are body, speech, and mind. The ground of mind, the five buddha bodies, liberation, emptiness, major marks and excellent features, and so forth — all of these are the suchness of wind.

Next, the suchness of the seminal drop (bindu): sun and moon are skillful means and wisdom. The garland of mantra syllables is the major and minor marks. The seminal drop is by nature the five wisdoms. It is the suchness of non-duality. Its subtler aspects and so forth are to be understood from elsewhere.

Then the lower doors are to be explained as suchness: the three channels are the essential nature of body, speech, and mind. The five channels are the five wisdoms. The caṇḍālī is twenty-four in number, the suchness being twenty-four wisdoms, the enlightened activities of the dharmakāya being twenty-four. The union of skillful means and wisdom is free from both dripping and blazing — these are non-dual. The four wheels are the four buddha bodies. The six are the six suchnesses. Tārā is the suchness of wind. Fire is the essential nature of the white garment. The sixteen are the sixteen emptinesses. The four are the four wisdoms. Liberation, emptiness, major and minor marks, mantra awareness, subtle absorptions numbering nine, the fifty wisdoms and so on — these are definitively the suchness of the channel-petals.

The sequential arrangement of these channels: from the hub of the wheel, they coil to the right and left like a snake, and on the outside bow to the right and left like a bow. By virtue of the third, the suchness is also this: saffron is wisdom and the dharmadhātu, camphor is the four wisdoms of skillful means. The channel abides in the place of Akaniṣṭha. Supreme joy and ordinary joy are the factors of awakening. Natural joy is the dharmakāya. The joy of freedom is the two form bodies. The sixteen are the sixteen emptinesses.

In the manner of tantra — a mere illusion — whoever seeks self-awareness should first understand the essential nature, and then come to know the suchness. If one meditates on the profound path itself without understanding the suchness, there will be no fruit and ruin is certain.

If one does not know the suchness of the deity, one is like a demon dwelling in a charnel ground. Likewise, like a demoness in a charnel ground. If one does not know the suchness of conduct, one is like a madman wandering in a city — like dogs, pigs, demons, and rākṣasas. If one does not know the suchness of the hand-emblem, one is like Śakra (Indra) holding a weapon in his hand. If one does not know the suchness of the mudrā, one is like a king with a queen on his lap. If one does not know the suchness of wind, one is like smoke rising from the crown of Śakra's head. If one does not know the suchness of the channels, one is like a sandalwood tree producing emanations and the like.

If one does not know the suchness of the impurities of the body, one is like the secretions of the body, like water. If one does not know the suchness of the bindu (Skt. bindu), one is like the ooze of a sandalwood tree. If one does not know the suchness of the wheel (cakra), one is like Śakra holding a wheel in his hand — and likewise like the wheel of existence. If one does not know the suchness of the lotus, one is like a lotus growing in a swamp. If one does not know the suchness of the dense or thick, one is like the wheel of a stūpa. If one does not know the suchness of union, one is like the right and left palms pressed together. If one does not know the suchness of the place, one is like the palace of a wheel-turning king. If one does not know the suchness of the awakening mind (bodhicitta), one is like the spittle issuing from the gate of an unclean passage. If one does not know the suchness of Siṃhala, one is like blood drawn from weapons and the like. If one does not know the suchness of joy, one is like the desire of a prostitute. If one does not know the suchness of what is to be abandoned, one is like a king without a city. If one does not know the suchness of the antidote, one is like a city without a king. If one does not know the suchness of self-awareness, one is like a conditioned thing — an empty sky.

Furthermore, these twenty-eight suchnesses must be understood from the mouth of a guru. All of this is like the manner of illusion, like a dream, like lightning, like a cloud. If one knows suchness, one will be liberated.

Alas! O great compassionate Protector — in seeking the primordial wisdom (jñāna) of self-awareness, is there any distinction between one's own and others' schools in this regard?

The Blessed One declared: That very suchness is the great distinction. For others, the distinction lies in the fourfold empowerment and the investigation of the suchness of its path. Through nihilism regarding the self, through the

Lord (Īśvara), through fate, and through the notion of a creator, these are superseded by what is taught in the tantra regarding causes and so forth. Because it is free from a personal self, the śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and the Great Vehicle are bound by a self of phenomena such as wind and the like, and are pervaded by the perception of the inferior. The Great Vehicle is distinguished by its divine nature; and the great distinction of suchness among Yoga, Great Yoga, and the rest is that it has been excellently taught — so hold it well.

Then all members of the retinue became joyful and elated.

The King of Tantras, the Tantra of the Suchness of the Secret Wisdom of the Glorious Vajrasattva, is complete.

This was translated by the Indian yoginī Candramālā and the translator, the monk Śākya Yeshe.

Translator's Notes

- The colophon identifies this as the conclusion of one text and the opening of a new one: the King of Tantras of Glorious Secret Wisdom (Śrī Jñānaguhyatantrarāja), translated by the celebrated paṇḍita Gayādhara and Śākya Yeshe, a significant Tibetan translation team active in the eleventh century.

The term rendered "caṇḍālī" (Tib. tsaṇḍālī) refers to the inner heat or tummo practice central to completion-stage yoga; it is left in its Sanskrit form as a recognized technical term of the tantric tradition.

The phrase "the suchness of the fourth" refers to the fourth empowerment in the fourfold empowerment system of the higher tantras, namely the word empowerment pointing directly to the nature of mind.

The simile of Śakra holding a weapon and the image of a king with a queen on his lap are traditional tantric analogies illustrating the misuse or ignorance of ritual implements and mudrās when their inner meaning is unknown; the passage does not imply negative judgment of those persons in themselves but rather the absurdity of the external act without inner realization.

- The term rendered "impurities of the body" and "secretions of the body" translates two parallel phrases contrasting the body's accumulations of filth with its fluid impurities; the verse is intentionally terse and possibly corrupt, and the precise referent of each simile in the bindu-related lines may vary across manuscript traditions. The phrase "suchness of Siṃhala" likely refers to a tantric technical usage of the term Siṃhala (perhaps denoting a particular esoteric substance or practice associated with that name), rather than the island of Sri Lanka; this is left transliterated as the Tibetan does not clarify it further. The count of twenty-eight suchnesses is given explicitly in the text; enumeration across the preceding passage and this one should be reconciled by a reader with access to a commentary. The phrase translated "bound by a self of phenomena such as wind and the like" refers to the cognitive obscuration of dharma-selflessness remaining present in the lower vehicles, according to the Vajrayāna

doctrinal context of the text.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.